Digital Documentation

The big idea

A **word processor** lets you create, edit, format, save and print documents such as letters, reports and notices. You will use **LibreOffice Writer**, a free, open-source word processor. Its default file format is **.odt** (OpenDocument Text), but it can also save as .docx, .pdf and more.

Starting Writer and the interface

Open it from **Applications > Office > LibreOffice Writer** (Ubuntu) or the Start menu (Windows). The window has:

- **Title bar** (document name), **Menu bar** (File, Edit, View, Insert, Format, Styles, Table, Form, Tools, Window, Help)
- **Standard** and **Formatting** toolbars, **ruler**, the **work area**, the **sidebar** and the **status bar** (page number, word count, zoom).

Creating, saving and opening documents

- **New**: **File > New > Text Document** (Ctrl+N).
- **Save**: **File > Save** (Ctrl+S) → choose folder, type name → Save. **Save As** (Ctrl+Shift+S) saves a copy with a new name or format (choose *Word 2007–365 (.docx)* in *File type* to share with MS Word users).
- **Export as PDF**: **File > Export as PDF**.
- **Open**: **File > Open** (Ctrl+O). **Close**: **File > Close**.

Editing text

Task	Menu / shortcut
Select all	Ctrl+A
Cut / Copy / Paste	Ctrl+X / Ctrl+C / Ctrl+V
Undo / Redo	Ctrl+Z / Ctrl+Y
Find & Replace	**Edit > Find & Replace** (Ctrl+H)
Spelling	**Tools > Spelling** (F7); red wavy lines mark errors when **Automatic Spell Checking** (Shift+F7) is on
Insert special character	**Insert > Special Character**

Formatting text and paragraphs

- **Character formatting** (Format > Character): font name, size, colour, **bold (Ctrl+B)**, *italic (Ctrl+I)*, underline (Ctrl+U), superscript (Ctrl+Shift+P), subscript (Ctrl+Shift+B), highlighting.
- **Paragraph formatting** (Format > Paragraph): alignment – left (Ctrl+L), centre (Ctrl+E), right (Ctrl+R), justified (Ctrl+J); indents; line spacing; space before/after.
- **Bullets and numbering**: **Format > Bullets and Numbering**, or toolbar buttons.
- **Change case**: **Format > Text > UPPERCASE / lowercase**.

Page setup, headers and footers

- **Format > Page Style**: paper size (A4), orientation (portrait/landscape), margins, borders, background.
- **Insert > Header and Footer > Header/Footer > Default Page Style** adds a header or footer. Insert page numbers with **Insert > Page Number** (or **Insert > Field > Page Number**).

- **Insert > Page Break** (Ctrl+Enter) starts a new page.

Tables

Tables arrange data in **rows** and **columns**; each box is a **cell**.

- **Insert**: **Table > Insert Table** (Ctrl+F12) → set columns, rows, heading → **Insert**.
- **Add rows/columns**: **Table > Insert > Rows Above/Below** or **Columns Before/After**.
- **Delete**: **Table > Delete > Rows / Columns / Table**.
- **Merge cells**: select cells → **Table > Merge Cells**. **Split**: **Table > Split Cells**.
- **Borders and shading**: **Table > Properties** → Borders / Background tabs.
- Use **Tab** to move to the next cell; pressing Tab in the last cell adds a new row.

MAKE A TIMETABLE

1. Ctrl+F12 → 6 columns, 7 rows → Insert.
2. Type days in the first column and periods in the first row.
3. Select the first row → make it **Bold** and shade it with **Table > Properties > Background**.
4. Save as Timetable.odt.

Images and printing

- **Insert > Image** to add a picture; right-click → **Wrap** to set how text flows around it.
- **File > Print Preview** (Ctrl+Shift+O) to check layout; **File > Print** (Ctrl+P) to choose printer, pages and copies.

SAVE VS SAVE AS

Save updates the current file. **Save As** makes a new copy with a new name/format; the original stays unchanged.

SHORTCUT QUESTIONS

Ctrl+E centre, Ctrl+J justify, Ctrl+H find & replace, F7 spelling, Ctrl+F12 insert table, Ctrl+Enter page break.

Quick recap

- Writer default format: .odt; can save as .docx and export to PDF.
- Edit with cut/copy/paste, undo/redo, find & replace, spelling (F7).
- Format characters, paragraphs, bullets and page style; add headers/footers and page numbers.
- Tables: Ctrl+F12, insert/delete rows, merge and split cells.

Practice questions

1. The default file extension of a LibreOffice Writer document is
   (a) .odt (b) .ods (c) .odp (d) .txt
2. Which shortcut opens the Find & Replace dialog in Writer?
   (a) Ctrl+F12 (b) Ctrl+R (c) Ctrl+H (d) F7
3. To check spelling in a Writer document, press
   (a) F5 (b) F11 (c) F2 (d) F7
4. The shortcut to insert a table in Writer is
   (a) Ctrl+T (b) Ctrl+F12 (c) Ctrl+Shift+T (d) Alt+T
5. Which alignment spreads text evenly from the left to the right margin?
   (a) Left (b) Centre (c) Right (d) Justified
6. Combining two or more table cells into one is called
   (a) splitting cells (b) merging cells (c) deleting cells (d) wrapping cells
7. To keep the original file and save a copy with a new name, use
   (a) Save (b) Close (c) Save As (d) Print Preview
8. Write the steps to add a header and page numbers to a Writer document.
9. Write the steps to insert a table with 4 columns and 5 rows in Writer, add one more row at the end and merge the cells of the first row.

Answers: 1. a 2. c 3. d 4. b 5. d 6. b 7. c 8. see notes 9. see notes